THE SAFFRON FIELDS

On a warm spring day in 1576, Akbar brought Kuar Man Singh to Khwaja Muinuddin Chishti's tomb at Ajmer and, in the sanctified precinct of the saint's grave, surrounded by the murmuring of the praying pilgrims, wisps of incense, and the charged atmosphere of more than three centuries of benedictions, presented the young Rajput prince with a robe of honour and sent him to war. For what was to become one of the most contested battles between the Mughal Empire and a Rajput king, one whose legacy would reverberate into the twenty-first century, was in fact fought between two Rajput leaders and it would be most extravagantly glorified by a British chronicler and an agent of the British Empire, Colonel James Tod.

By 1576, large swathes of Rajasthan including Amer, Bikaner, Jaisalmer, and Sirohi, had become part of the Mughal Empire through a mix of military force and marriage alliances. But Mewar was a land with a particularly blood-drenched past in which the fires of jauhar had smouldered on three separate occasions. This was a land of uncompromising valour in which the honour of the Sisodiya clan was deeply, violently invested in the chastity of its women. When Rana Pratap ascended the gaddi of Mewar in 1572 upon the death of his father, Udai Singh, substantial parts of Mewar, including Chittor and Mandalgarh, were already part of the Mughal Empire. In fact, Rana Pratap's half-brother Jagmal, favourite of their father, Udai Singh, was an honoured jagirdar in Akbar's empire. Akbar had also tried on at least three separate occasions to persuade Rana Pratap to integrate into the empire with honour, sending Kuar Man Singh, Raja Bhagwant Das, and Raja Todar Mal to parley with him. According to historian Rima Hooja, during one of these attempts, Rana Pratap had contemplated compromise. He put on the imperial robe forwarded to him by Akbar and sent his eldest son Amar along with Bhagwant Das to wait upon the Padshah. He baulked, however, at the idea of going in person to the Mughal court and negotiations broke down. For Rana Pratap there would now be a complete rejection not only of the Mughal Empire but also of those Rajputs who had 'polluted' their pure blood by marrying daughters to the Mughals. There were also signs that the